

- RAG Learning

1.9 Pressure Groups

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 1 (Government and Politics of the UK)

Pressure groups seek to **influence** government policy without seeking to **form** a government — the defining distinction from political parties. The specification also requires you to consider other collective organisations: think tanks, lobbyists and corporations.

1. Typology

Sectional vs promotional

	Sectional (interest) groups	Promotional (cause) groups
Represent	A particular section of society — usually occupational or economic	A cause or value, not members' own material interest
Membership	Restricted to those who share the characteristic	Open to anyone who supports the aim
Examples	British Medical Association, Unite, National Farmers' Union, CBI	Greenpeace, Amnesty International, Liberty, Shelter

The distinction is not always clean: unions campaigning on wider social policy perform both roles.

Insider vs outsider

	Insider groups	Outsider groups
Access	Regular, privileged consultation; sit on advisory committees; supply technical	No such access — either because government is unsympathetic, or by

	expertise	choice
Methods	Quiet negotiation with ministers and civil servants	Demonstrations, direct action, media campaigns
Examples	BMA on health; NFU on agriculture	Extinction Rebellion; Just Stop Oil

Exam Tip: Insider status involves a genuine **trade-off**, and saying so is worth marks. Privileged access normally requires moderating demands and accepting confidentiality — which limits the group's ability to campaign publicly or mobilise supporters. Status can also change with the government of the day: trade unions were insiders under Labour in the 1970s and outsiders under Thatcher, with membership largely unchanged.

2. Methods

- **Lobbying** — ministers, civil servants and MPs; submitting evidence to select committees and consultations. Most effective at the *drafting* stage, before positions harden.
- **Media campaigning** — shifting public opinion to create political costs for inaction. Marcus Rashford's free school meals campaign is the standard modern example of a celebrity-led campaign forcing a reversal.
- **Petitions, demonstrations and marches** — demonstrating the scale of support.
- **Direct action and civil disobedience** — Extinction Rebellion, Insulate Britain.
- **Legal action** — judicial review and Human Rights Act challenges to the lawfulness of government decisions.
- **Research and expertise** — supplying evidence departments lack.

3. What makes a group successful?

Factor	Why it matters
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Alignment with the government's agenda	The most reliable predictor. A group pushing where government already wants to go succeeds with modest effort; one opposing settled policy may fail regardless of resources
Resources	Funding buys professional lobbying, research, legal action and sustained campaigning — which is why business groups exert influence disproportionate to their numbers
Expertise and insider status	Groups whose specialist knowledge government needs become embedded in the policy process
Public support and salience	Demonstrable public backing creates political costs for inaction — how the Snowdrop campaign secured handgun legislation after Dunblane
Strategic skill and timing	Exploiting a crisis, a scandal or a change of government
Organisation	A professional, well-led group outperforms a larger but chaotic one

Exam Tip: Do not argue that **size of membership** determines success — it is one of the weakest predictors. The Countryside Alliance mobilised huge marches and lost on hunting; small, well-connected professional bodies routinely win. Influence tracks access and alignment, not numbers, which is the core of the elitist critique.

4. Other collective organisations

Think tanks

Research organisations producing policy analysis to shape debate — the Institute for Fiscal Studies, Institute of Economic Affairs, Adam Smith Institute, Resolution Foundation. Their significance is **agenda-setting**: much of the Thatcher government's programme was developed in think tanks before becoming policy. They also supply governments with ideas and personnel. The recurring criticism is **opacity of funding**, which makes it difficult to know whose interests a report serves.

Corporations

Large firms exert influence through a channel unavailable to other groups: because governments depend on investment, employment and tax revenue, the **anticipated reaction of business constrains policy even without active lobbying**. This is "structural power", and it is the strongest single piece of evidence for the elitist account. Corporations also fund professional lobbying, employ former officials and supply technical expertise during consultation.

Lobbying firms and regulation

- Professional intermediaries employed to secure access on clients' behalf.
- The **Lobbying Act 2014** created a register of consultant lobbyists and regulated non-party campaign spending at elections.
- **Widely regarded as ineffective:** the register covers only *consultant* lobbyists, excluding the in-house lobbyists who conduct the majority of lobbying, while the spending restrictions chiefly burdened charities and campaigners.
- The **revolving door** — movement of officials and ministers into lobbying and industry roles — remains a live concern.

5. Pluralism vs elitism

Pluralism	Elitism
Power is dispersed among many competing groups; government arbitrates between them	Power is concentrated in a small, well-resourced minority whose interests dominate policy
Any interest that organises can enter the competition	Influence tracks wealth, organisation and access — not the number of people affected
Groups give intense minorities a continuous voice that elections cannot register	Diffuse public interests are consistently defeated by concentrated private ones
Groups supply expertise, improving policy quality	Business enjoys structural leverage no membership campaign can match

The defensible synthesis: the UK is *pluralist in form but elitist in effect*. Competition between groups is genuine and outcomes often reflect compromise — but pluralism assumes rough parity of access, and that assumption does not hold.

6. Do pressure groups enhance or undermine democracy?

Enhance

- **Continuous representation** between elections, when voters would otherwise have no voice.
- **Intense minorities get heard** — an electoral system cannot register how *strongly* a view is held.
- **Represent those who cannot vote** — children, future generations, non-citizens, animals.
- **Improve policy** through specialist input and by exposing unintended consequences.
- **Disperse power** and scrutinise implementation, including through judicial review.

Undermine

- **Unequal influence** — a well-funded minority can defeat a diffuse majority, inverting the democratic principle.
- **Unaccountable** — groups are not elected, need not be internally democratic, and bear no responsibility for consequences.
- **Opaque funding**, particularly for think tanks.
- **Illegal direct action** imposes costs on uninvolved members of the public and can be seen as attempting to override democratic decisions.

7. Rising use of the courts

Judicial review and the Human Rights Act have made litigation a serious route for UK groups, offering influence that bypasses an unsympathetic political majority. Liberty and environmental groups have used it extensively.

The limits matter: UK courts cannot strike down an Act of Parliament, so groups can challenge only executive action and secondary or devolved legislation, or seek a declaration of incompatibility that leaves the Act in force. A government can usually retake the decision lawfully or legislate around an

adverse ruling — and the **Judicial Review and Courts Act 2022** narrowed the remedies available, which is itself evidence of how significant the route had become.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Pressure group	An organisation seeking to influence policy without seeking to form a government
Sectional / interest group	Represents a particular section of society; restricted membership
Promotional / cause group	Campaigns for a cause; open membership
Insider group	Enjoys regular privileged access to decision-makers
Outsider group	Lacks such access; relies on public campaigning and direct action
Pluralism	Power dispersed among many competing groups, government arbitrating
Elitism	Power concentrated in a small, well-resourced minority
Structural power	Influence arising from government's dependence on business investment and employment
Revolving door	Movement of personnel between government and lobbying or industry
Think tank	A research organisation producing policy analysis to shape debate

Essential examples

- **Snowdrop campaign** — handgun legislation after Dunblane; public salience overcoming an organised opposing lobby.

- **Marcus Rashford, 2020** — free school meals reversal; media and celebrity campaigning.
- **Countryside Alliance** — large marches, lost on hunting; size is not decisive.
- **BMA and NFU** — classic insider groups with embedded consultation.
- **Extinction Rebellion** — direct action shifting the agenda; also prompting restrictions on protest.
- **Lobbying Act 2014** — a register excluding in-house lobbyists; regulation widely judged ineffective.
- **Judicial Review and Courts Act 2022** — government narrowing a route groups had come to rely on.